Robert (Bob) Arons, Ph.D.

Managing Economist, Freshwater Prestige Economics
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PROFILE

Antitrust economist and founder of Freshwater Prestige Economics. More than a decade of experience applying econometric and theoretical analysis to class certification and overcharge analyses in cartel and class action litigation, merger review, and the evaluation of alleged anticompetitive conduct, including market definition, competitive effects, and damages. Spent six years as a staff economist in the Antitrust Division of the U.S. Department of Justice (2014–2020), receiving three Assistant Attorney General's Awards, and later led class certification and overcharge analyses at Secretariat International. Matters span health insurance and healthcare, telecommunications and media, technology, agriculture, and building materials.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Freshwater Prestige Economics Feb 2023–present
Managing Economist and Founder

- Founded Freshwater Prestige Economics, which serves outside and in-house counsel as consulting and testifying experts on mergers, alleged anticompetitive conduct, class certification, and damages.
- Conducts economic modeling, empirical data analysis, report writing, and presentations.

Virginia Department of Social Services Nov 2023–present
Director of Research and Planning and Chief Data Officer

- Oversees three teams (Research, Data Warehouse, and Data Governance) comprising 27 staff; reorganized the research system to streamline research and evaluation requests. As Chief Data Officer, leads the agency's data governance and data strategy.

Secretariat International (formerly Economists Inc.) Feb 2020–Feb 2023
Associate Director Jul 2022–Feb 2023
Senior Economist Feb 2020–Jun 2022

- Led class certification and overcharge analyses and analyzed alleged cartels' effects on price and output in agriculture, building materials, and healthcare matters.
- Performed economic and financial modeling, wrote technical reports, and presented findings; managed teams of economists and research assistants and project budgets; recruited and hired staff.

U.S. Department of Justice, Antitrust Division 2014–2020
Staff Economist

- Analyzed mergers and conduct for Division leadership, including market definition, competitive effects, and efficiencies; led teams of economists; received three Assistant Attorney General's Awards.
- Reviewed studies and disseminated findings; served as ArcGIS liaison and economic knowledge liaison; established best practices in data management and collection.

Other positions

Data Analyst, Aetna 2008
Research Assistant on Medicare claims research (Prof. Dan Kessler), Stanford University 2006–2008

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics, University of Rochester 2014
M.A. in Economics, University of Rochester 2010
B.A. in Economics, cum laude, Case Western Reserve University 2006

AWARDS AND FELLOWSHIPS

Assistant Attorney General's Award, Antitrust Division, U.S. Department of Justice 2015, 2017, 2019
Best Empirical Project, Economic Analysis Group, U.S. Department of Justice 2015
Graduate Fellowship and Tuition Scholarship, University of Rochester 2008–2014

TEACHING

Georgetown University, Adjunct Instructor, ECON 562 Industrial Organization (master's) Spring 2019, Spring 2020
University of Rochester, Course Instructor, ECO 108 Principles of Economics Summer 2011
Teaching Assistant: MKT 414 Pricing Policy (graduate); ECO 231 Econometrics; ECO 230 Economic Statistics; ECO 207 Intermediate Economics; ECO 108 Principles of Economics (2010–2013)
Case Western Reserve University, TA, ECON 342 Public Finance; ECON 378 Healthcare Economics 2005–2006

RESEARCH AND PRESENTATIONS

Working papers

- "Do Bigger Firms Get Better Terms? Evidence from Pay TV," with Alexander Raskovich.
- "Size Effects and Bargaining Power in the Multichannel Television Industry," with Nikolay Doudchenko and Ali Yurukoglu.
- "The Impact of HMOs on Preventive Care and Undiagnosed Conditions Along the Life-Cycle."
- "The Effect of Race-Based Achievement Goals on the Achievement Gap."
- "Cost Sharing and Price Competition in MRI Services," with Mark Votruba (work in progress).

Presentations and panels

Panel: "Vertically Challenged: An AT&T/TWX Retrospective," ABA webinar Nov 2021
EARIE, Barcelona GSE, Barcelona, Spain 2019
Stockman Conference, University of Rochester 2018
DC Industrial Organization Day, Compass Lexecon and Maryland Center for Economics and Policy 2017
14th Annual International Industrial Organization Conference, Drexel University 2016

SELECTED MATTERS

Consulting (Secretariat International)

Competition Commission of India Suo Motu Case No. 2 of 2019, CCI v. ACC Limited and Ambuja Cements Limited
Anthony Colucci and Vanessa Lorraine Skipper, Individually and on Behalf of Those Similarly Situated v. Health First, Inc.
In re Broiler Chicken Antitrust Litigation
In re Broiler Chicken Grower Litigation
Linus Gilbert and James Jn-Marie v. Spartan Concrete Products, LLC and Heavy Materials, LLC
North American Soccer League, LLC v. United States Soccer Federation, Inc. and Major League Soccer, LLC

U.S. Department of Justice, Antitrust Division

Merger reviews: AT&T/Time Warner; Anthem/Cigna; Aetna/Humana; Comcast/Time Warner Cable; T-Mobile/Sprint; Google/Looker; Slack/Atlassian; Scripps/Nexstar; National Beef/Iowa Premium; Iron Mountain/Recall
U.S. and the State of North Carolina v. Carolinas HealthCare System (now Atrium Health)
U.S. v. Custom Wristbands, Inc.; U.S. v. Christopher Angeles; U.S. v. Netbrands; and U.S. v. Yeh Fei Chu and G Nova Corporation

EXPERT REPORTS

In the Matter of Competition Commission of India Suo Motu Case No. 2 of 2019, Competition Commission of India (CCI) v. ACC Limited and Ambuja Cements Limited, before the Competition Commission of India. Signed expert report submitted to the CCI (prepared at Secretariat International).

PUBLICATIONS

Review of *Controlling Mergers and Market Power: A Program for Reviving Antitrust in America*, *Economists Ink*, 2021.

DATA AND SOFTWARE

Stata, R, Python, SAS, SQL, ArcGIS, Unix, Excel; machine learning text analysis; large transaction, claims, survey, and geolocation datasets.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Economics Editor, ABA Media and Technology News e-Bulletin 2021–present
Graduate in Leadership (professional development), Virginia Executive Institute, Richmond, VA 2024

BOARDS & APPOINTMENTS

Member (VDSS Designee), Commonwealth of Virginia Executive Data Board 2024–present
Office of Data Governance and Analytics, Richmond, VA

- Represents the Department of Social Services on the statutory, CDO-chaired board that sets and approves KPIs for data-governance initiatives, reviews the cross-agency data and analytics project portfolio for prioritization and funding, and promotes data sharing among executive-branch agencies.